

Peterson to enter Softball Hall

By Chuck Hackenmiller
Staff Writer

Tom Peterson, Cedar Falls, played for the 1967 Boone High School state championship baseball team.

Now, at the age of 45, he's reached another plateau in athletic accomplishments. Not in baseball, but fast-pitch softball.

On Saturday during the Amateur Softball Association state tournament at the Kirkwood Softball Complex in Cedar Rapids, Peterson will be inducted into the Iowa Amateur Softball Association Hall of Fame. Prior to the ceremony, Peterson's family and friends will be treated to a dinner at Swisher.

"This is a nice honor. I put in a lot of years playing softball — made a lot of trips and road miles with a lot of good people," said Peterson. He is an associate director of information systems and computer services at the University of Northern Iowa in Cedar Falls.

Peterson, 45, started his softball career in 1971 with Hall of Fame Coach Everett Long's Boone Merchants. When the Merchant team broke up in 1974, he played for the Ames-Palmas team for the rest of the 1974 season.

"I had a good time playing in Boone. Everett (Long) was a heck of a good man and a very good coach. It was very hard to move on. Leaving such a fine coach like him was what made it so hard to do," Peterson said.

Long, Boone, said Peterson was a talented ballplayer for the Boone Merchants. "He was a good left-handed hitter with good bat speed. He was able to lay down a bunt and beat it out and also was a player that could whack it over the fence for you," said Long.

Peterson was asked to join the Des Moines Peters Bombers, but he decided to stay with Ames-Palmas in 1974. His Ames team qualified for state that year, but it was the Bombers from Des Moines that won the state title.

Peterson made the Bombers squad in 1975, where he worked hard to become the team's cleanup hitter. There, he didn't have to dodge inside pitches, but more often had to scramble from teammate Tom Stokesbary's bat. Stokesbary batted in the Bombers' lineup before Peterson.

"I thought batting cleanup was a distinction. But actually, it was a case of who was fool enough to try avoiding Stokesbary's bat flying back to the dugout when he didn't get to base because some pitcher 'couldn't



Tom Peterson

Played fast-pitch softball for 19 years, starting his career with the Boone Merchants in 1971.

throw the ball hard enough to break a pane of glass'. Stoke and I signed that petition outlawing the change-up every year we played together," Peterson said.

While with the Bombers, Peterson was among the team's top power hitters. His first year with the Bombers, he led the Iowa A.S.A. State Softball Tournament field of players in homers.

The Bombers, a familiar team at the state tournaments year after year, shared the state team title with Cedar Rapids-Modern Piping in 1979. In that tournament, Peterson received Most Valuable Player honors for hitting .429 in five games, smacking a homer and driving in five runs.

The Bombers went on to win the Mid-West Regional in Omaha, then the team participated in the Amateur Softball Association National Tournament. He was one at-bat short of qualifying for the official batting average title of the national tournament. "I could have struck out in that one at-bat and still won the batting title," Peterson said.

The Des Moines Bombers finished ninth in the nation that year.

After 1980, when Bomber team sponsor Bill Peters retired, many players joined the Reames Noodle team. In 1982, the team became the Des Moines Coors Bombers. That year, Peterson was again on a state championship Bomber team. Two

years later, Peterson earned Most Valuable Player honors again at the Amateur Softball Association state tournament with the Des Moines Like Bombers.

Peterson also played for Cedar Rapids Vigortone in 1985, Waterloo Turf Control in 1986 and Des Moines LaPizza Bombers in 1987.

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Bomber teammates on the Moines B-40 Bombers and participated in the Amateur Softball Association National Tournament Masters 40-Over in Omaha," son said.

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Bomber teammates on the Des Moines B-40 Bombers and participated in the Amateur Softball Association National Tournament Men's Masters 40-Over in Omaha," Peterson said.

"I received first team All-American honors for my accomplishments in that 1990 tournament," he said.

"Twice winning the MVP award at the state tournament, almost winning the battle title at the national tournament and the first-team All-American selection — those distinctions have great meaning for me."

Peterson said he doesn't play softball anymore. "The doctor wants me to be able to use my knees, so that put a damper on it," he said.